

AUSTRALIA

Key Country Details Table

Detail	Information
Full Name	Commonwealth of Australia
Short Form	Australia
Capital	Canberra
Region (UN)	Western European and Others Group (WEOG)
Government Type	Federal parliamentary constitutional monarchy
Head of State	King Charles III (represented by Governor-General Sam Mostyn)
Head of Government	Prime Minister Anthony Albanese
Currency	Australian Dollar (AUD)
UN Member Since	1945 (Founding Member)
MUN Standing	Active middle power; often serves as a bridge between developed and developing nations; emphasizes multilateralism and regional stability.

Recommended Books on Australia's Foreign Policy and UN Engagement

- "Fear of Abandonment: Australia in the World Since 1942"** – Allan Gyngell
A comprehensive analysis of Australia's foreign policy decisions and its quest for security and relevance on the global stage.
- "Australian Foreign Policy: Controversies and Debates"** – Daniel Baldino et al.
Explores key debates shaping Australia's foreign policy, including its role in the UN and regional dynamics.
- "Australia in International Politics: An Introduction to Australian Foreign Policy"** – Derek McDougall
Provides insights into Australia's international relations and its engagement with global institutions.
- "The Howard Paradox: Australian Diplomacy in Asia 1996–2006"** – Michael Wesley
Analyzes Australia's diplomatic strategies in Asia during the Howard government era.
- "The Tragedy of Australian Foreign Policy"** – Michael Pembroke
Critiques Australia's foreign policy decisions and their implications for national sovereignty.

Research Table: Australia & UNHRC

Source Name	Link	Why It's Useful
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Australian Human Rights Commission	https://humanrights.gov.au	National body reporting on rights issues and shadow reports.
DFAT – Human Rights	https://www.dfat.gov.au/international-relations/themes/human-rights	Australia's foreign policy on human rights.
OHCHR Country Page – Australia	https://www.ohchr.org/en/countries/australia	Summary of Australia's interaction with OHCHR.
UPR Reports – Australia	https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/upr/au-index	Universal Periodic Review submissions and recommendations.
Human Rights Watch – Australia	https://www.hrw.org/asia/australia	Evaluations of Australia's rights record.
Amnesty International – Australia	https://www.amnesty.org.au	Human rights advocacy, local and international.
UNHRC Resolutions Search	https://digitallibrary.un.org/search?cc=Human+Rights+Council	Find resolutions Australia supported or debated.
Australian Law Reform Commission – Human Rights Reports	https://www.alrc.gov.au/publication-category/human-rights/	Insights into Australia's legal framework for rights.
Human Rights Law Centre (Australia)	https://www.hrlc.org.au	NGO shadow reports and UN advocacy.
Just Security – Australia & Human Rights	https://www.justsecurity.org	Articles and legal commentary on Australia's UN engagements.
UN Treaty Body Database	https://tbinternet.ohchr.org	Full archives of Australia's treaty compliance.
UN Human Rights Council Membership Info	https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/hrc/membership	Tracks Australia's election status and voting history.
Global Freedom Scores – Australia	https://freedomhouse.org/country/australia/freedom-world/2024	Context for Australia's rights standing globally.
Equality Australia	https://equalityaustralia.org.au	Rights advocacy especially on LGBTQ+ issues.
Australian Centre for International Justice	https://acij.org.au	Focuses on international law and Australia's compliance.

Source Name	Link	Why It's Useful
OHCHR – Australia Country Profile	https://www.ohchr.org/en/countries/australia (amnesty.org, ohchr.org)	Official summary of treaty status, OHCHR-Pacific cooperation, and Council mechanisms.

OHCHR – Australia UPR Index & Docs	https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/upr/au-index	Access to state UPR reports, NGO inputs, and recommendations.
HRW – World Report 2024 (Australia)	https://www.hrw.org/world-report/2024/country-chapters/australia	Critiques asylum policy and First Nations discrimination.
HRW – World Report 2023	https://www.hrw.org/world-report/2023/country-chapters/australia	Notes improvements on climate but flags rights gaps.
Amnesty – UPR Submission 2021 (PDF)	https://www.amnesty.org.au/wp-content/uploads/2021/01/Universal-Periodic-Review-2021_Australia_AIA.pdf	Covers Indigenous, asylum, and justice framework deficiencies.
Amnesty – UPR Outcome Statement	https://www.amnesty.org/fr/wp-content/uploads/2021/07/ASA1243902021ENGLISH.pdf	Details UN recommendations Australia has yet to accept.
OHCHR – Treaty Ratification Dashboard	https://tbinternet.ohchr.org/_layouts/TreatyBodyExternal/countries.aspx?CountryCode=AUS&Lang=EN	Shows Australia's treaty participation and reporting status.
OHCHR – Special Rapporteur Visits	https://spinternet.ohchr.org/ViewCountryVisits.aspx?Lang=en&country=AUS&visitType=all	Lists expert missions (assembly, torture, etc.)—indicative of scrutiny.
OHCHR – UPR Second Cycle Docs	https://www.ohchr.org/en/hr-bodies/upr/uprau-stakeholders-info-s23	NGO and state contributions for 2nd UPR cycle.
HRW – Local Asylum Manager Quote	https://asylumseekerscentre.org.au/human-rights-watch-condemns-australias-treatment ...	Illustrates NGO-led critique of asylum policy.
State Dept – U.S. HR Report on Australia 2023	https://www.state.gov/reports/2023-country-reports-on-human-rights-practices/australia/	Details labor rights, civil liberties, and asylum treatment.
HRW – World Report 2025 (ECOI)	https://www.ecoi.net/en/document/2120055.html	Confirms no national rights act and asylum issues.

Amnesty – Follow-Up UPR Submission (PDF)	https://uprdoc.ohchr.org/uprweb/downloadfile.aspx?file=EnglishTranslation&filename=8315	Highlights ongoing refugee rights violations.
HRW – Twitter Observation	https://x.com/hrw/status/1880438640829948353	Quick summary of Australia's mixed rights record.
OHCHR – Early 2021 UPR Submission	https://uprdoc.ohchr.org/uprweb/downloadfile.aspx?file=EnglishTranslation&filename=2189	Shows earlier lack of recommendation implementation.
Amnesty – 2015 UPR Submission	https://www.refworld.org/reference/annualreport/amnesty/2015/en/113841	Historical perspective on broader UPR issues.
AUS Gov – Australia & UNHRC Statements	https://www.dfat.gov.au/international-relations/themes/human-rights/hrc-statements	Official records of Australia's Council interventions.

10 Unique Aspects: Australia at UNHRC

1. **Offshore Asylum Scrutiny:** The ongoing criticism, with Human Rights Watch labeling the regime as “inhumane,” keeps Australia in the spotlight of the UN Human Rights Council regarding asylum issues.
2. **Youth Justice Regression:** The new laws around “adult crime time” and the practices for youth detention are raising serious concerns about human rights in Council discussions.
3. **First Nations Rights Gaps:** The ongoing issues of persistent disadvantage, excessive policing, and the removal of Indigenous children from their families really shine a light on the systemic racism that’s been under the UNHRC's scrutiny.
4. **Slave-like Domestic Worker Cases:** The Guardian's reports on diplomatic visa abuses have caught the Council's attention, highlighting the serious risks of forced labor.
5. **No National Rights Act Yet:** Australia stands out as the only Western democracy that lacks national human rights legislation, which has led to criticism during UN reviews.
6. **Frequent Special Rapporteur Visits:** Various expert missions (like torture, assembly, slavery, and so on) highlight the need for thorough monitoring at the UNHRC level.
7. **UPR Follow-Up Lags:** Persistent warnings from NGOs highlight significant shortcomings in how Australia is putting UPR recommendations into action.
8. **Dual Praise & Critique:** Australia is praised for its efforts in tackling climate change, yet it faces criticism regarding its treatment of asylum seekers and Indigenous rights—a complex picture painted by the UN.

9. **Robust NGO Leverage:** Amnesty and Human Rights Watch are key players in influencing the discussions within the Council, thanks to their submissions and public statements.
 10. **Global Advocacy with Domestic Limits:** Australia frequently takes the lead on UNHRC initiatives overseas, but the inconsistencies at home can undermine its credibility in Council discussions.
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